# Product Sprint.

**Areas to solve for:**

1. Meditation as a long term habit.
2. Best short term solution.
3. Solve for cheap dopamine hits

| Can our team build it? Feasibility | Will customers buy this? CustomerValue | Will this work for our business? Business Viability | Can users find out how to use it? Usability |
|---|---|---|---|
| 5<br>Leverages existing meditation content and instructors. Requires standard audio features (such as habit tracking, reminders, and sleep logs). Complexity is low but longer iteration cycles. | 9<br>Valuable for users seeking long-term stress reduction and improved sleep. Low relevance for users in acute sleep distress who need immediate fatigue moments. | 7<br>Strong retention and LTV driver. Reinforces Calm's positioning as a holistic wellness platform beyond sleep. | 7<br>Requires onboarding, education, and sustained motivation. Higher cognitive load than passive consumption compared to sleep use cases. |
| 8<br>Highly feasible using existing content and standard playback infrastructure. Requires orchestration logic and new entry points. Fast to prototype and test. | 8.5<br>Extremely high value for users in acute sleep need. Directly solves the primary job users come to Calm for at night and reduces time-to-sleep. | 8<br>Increases perceived product value, trust, and renewal likelihood. Calm from generic music & podcast apps and supports subscription renewal. | 7<br>One-tap, zero-decision experience. Designed for low cognitive energy users with minimal learning required. |
| 7<br>Moderate complexity due to system-level features (OS widgets, screen dimming, notifications) and possible within mobile-OS constraints but design-intensive. | 8<br>Strong emotional value for users stuck in scrolling loops. Helps users regain control without relying on willpower and builds trust. | 9<br>Strengthens Calm's differentiation as a counter-dopamine product. Long-term brand equity and loyalty benefit. | 9<br>Must be usable and feel supportive, not restrictive. Works best when automated and largely invisible to the user. |

Jobs to be done
1) Help me fall asleep
2) Help me relax
3) Make me less anxious
4) Help me focus
5) Be a companion
6) Routine

Meditation as a Long-Term Habit

- **Feasibility (9/10):** Calm already has strong meditation content and infrastructure; this is primarily a productization and habit-building problem.
- **Customer Value (8/10):** Strong value for users seeking stress reduction and improvements, but weak in moments of acute sleep distress.
- **Business Viability (8/10):** Strong driver of retention and lifetime value.
- **Usability (6/10):** Requires onboarding, motivation, and sustained effort; not well suited for low-cognitive-energy moments.

**Conclusion:** Good for the business long term, but not the right answer for the nighttime sleep moment.

Best Short Term Sleep Solution (Core Bet)

- **Feasibility (8/10):** Can be built using existing sleep content and playback systems; the key work is orchestration and decision removal.
- **Customer Value (9/10):** Directly solves the core job users open Calm for at night—falling asleep quickly.
- **Business Viability (8/10):** Improves perceived product value, trust, and renewal likelihood.
- **Usability (10/10):** One-tap, zero-decision experience designed for users with minimal cognitive energy.

**Conclusion:** Strongest fit for the core sleep use case.

Addressing Cheap Dopamine Distractions

- **Feasibility (7/10):** Requires system-level design and OS integrations; more complex but still achievable.
- **Customer Value (8/10):** High emotional value for users stuck in scrolling loops; reduces reliance on willpower.
- **Business Viability (8/10):** Strengthens Calm's differentiation as a counter-dopamine product and builds long-term trust.
- **Usability (7/10):** Must be opt-in and feel supportive rather than restrictive to avoid user resistance.

**Conclusion:** Not the first move, but a critical second-stage investment to build a defensible sleep experience.

In the sleep context, the short-term sleep solution should be the top priority; meditation builds long-term value, while reducing cheap dopamine distractions strengthens trust and differentiation over time.

| Area to Solve | Feasibility | Customer Value | Business Viability | Usability |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Meditation as a long term habit | 8/10 | 8/10 | 8/10 | 6/10 |
| Best short term sleep solution | 8/10 | 10/10 | 8/10 | 10/10 |
| Addressing cheap dopamine distractions | 7/10 | 8/10 | 8/10 | 7/10 |

**Summary Table**

| Focus Area | Value Risk | Usability Risk | Feasibility Risk | Viability Risk | Total Score |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Habit (Long Term) | 4 (High) | 2 (Low) | 2 (Low) | 1 (Low) | **9 (Safe)** |
| 2. SOS (Short Term) | 1 (Low) | 4 (High) | 3 (Med) | 2 (Low) | **10 (Balanced)** |
| 3. Dopamine (addiction) | 5 (High) | 3 (Med) | 5 (High) | 2 (Low) | **15 (Hard)** |

**1. Total Risk Score: 9/ 20** (range)**Safe but boring.** Habit tracking is a solved problem. This is good for **differentiation**, but good for business if it works.

**2. Total Risk Score: 10/20.** Medium-risk **Balanced High UX Challenge.** The design challenge here is minimizing clicks.

**3. Total Risk Score: 15/20**(range)**The Hard Problem.** This is the hardest problem to solve, but the most innovative.

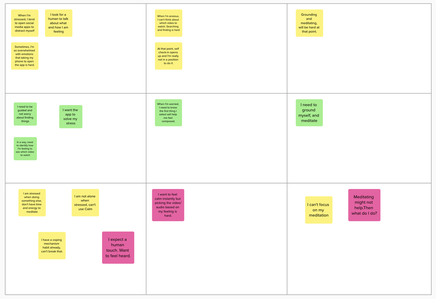
**The Scoring Scale:**

- **1 (Low Risk)** Safe bet, easy to do.
- **3 (Medium Risk)** Requires design finesse or careful testing, but manageable.
- **5 (High Risk)** The "Make or Break" challenge. High uncertainty.

**Gemini output:**
**Focus Area: 2: The "SOS" Button (Acute Stress)**
Concept: "Calm Now" — A panic button or widget that launches a 60-second intervention for immediate overwhelm.

- **Value Risk (Do users want this?) Score 1/5**
  - *The Risk:* Users experiencing a panic attack or high stress, the value of immediate relief is enormous. The demand is undeniable.
- **Usability Risk (Can they figure it out?) Score 4/5**
  - *The Risk:* High friction is fatal here. If a stressed user has to unlock their phone, find the app, wait for a load screen, and scroll to find content, the feature fails. The UI must be accessible *outside* the app (widgets, lock screen).
- **Feasibility Risk (Can we build it?) Score 3/5**
  - *The Risk:* Building a standard feature is easy. Building a rock-screen widget or an Apple Watch integration (which is ideal for this) is harder for a 3-day prototype.
- **Business Viability Risk (Does it work for the biz?) Score 2/5**
  - *The Risk:* Good for brand trust ("Calm saved me"), but doesn't necessarily drive daily usage, which subscriptions rely on.

**Total Risk Score:** 10/20 (Medio) **High Impact, High UX Challenge.** The design challenge here is minimizing clicks.




Solutions/Ideas :

1. Deep breath
2. low impact movement (things outside of the app
3. laughter and companionship
4. journaling
5. zero digital entry (one tap sleep now mode)
6. guided sleep transition
7.

Short term Solutions for sleep, stress & Anxiety
1) Picking up the app
2) Effort in the app
3) Solution has to provide Relief
4) Finding the best personalised solution

| A | B | C | D |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Category** | **The Reality (Current State)** | **The Gap (Why it fails today)** | **The Sprint Fix (Our Solution)** |
| **1. Internal Audit(Does Calm have this?)** | Calm has "Emergency Calm" and "Breathe Bubble" content, but it sits deep inside the library menu. | High Friction: A panic attack reduces cognitive function. Users cannot navigate Open App > Search > Scroll > Play while hyperventilating. | "0-Click Access": Move the solution outside the app structure using a Lock Screen Widget or Force Touch Action. |
| **2. Competitors(Who is winning?)** | Rootd (Big red button, ugly UI), Apple Watch (Haptic breathing), Dare (Audio SOS). | Competitors are either Fast but Ugly (Rootd) or Pretty but Slow (Headspace). No one combines speed with Calm's premium aesthetic. | "The Beautiful Button": Create a UI that is as Instant as Rootd but uses Calm's soothing visual language (blue, gradients, soft motion). |
| **3. Scientific Basis(How to stop panic?)** | Most apps play soothing music or spoken word stories. | Audio isn't enough. Acute panic requires Physiological Intervention (controlling the nervous system directly). | "Physiological Sigh": Focus on the Double Inhale / Long Exhale pattern (Huberman Lab) + Haptics (vibration) to ground the user physically. |
| **4. AI & Gamification(The "Magic" Tech)** | Current SOS tools are static (same track every time). Explicit "scores" cause performance anxiety. | Lack of Adaptation: If "Box Breathing" doesn't work, the user feels like they failed. | "Implicit Gamification": Use a visual avatar (e.g., a cloud) that clears as you breathe. AI Logic: If pulse stays high, the AI switches techniques automatically. |

**Learnings from the Design Sprint:**

1. Zoomed in on CUJ. Zoomed out to understand that SOS for stress is an issue - pivoted from CUJ of sleep to bigger issue of stress and anxiety
2. Keeping track of larger goal is sometimes hard when you're solving a specific problem
3. Used Frameworks to break down problems into smaller categories (SVPG Risk)
4. You are not the user!

**Problem 2 — Calm Requires Engagement When Users Want to Disengage**
The sleep experience asks users to stay cognitively and digitally engaged at the very moment they want to mentally and physically disengage from their devices.

**Problem 4 — The Experience Competes With Other Digital Dopamine**
When Calm's sleep flow feels effortful or slow to deliver relief, users are easily pulled toward social media or other apps that offer faster, more familiar stimulation.

**Problem 3 — Lack of Clear Guidance Creates Uncertainty**
Users lack confidence that they are making the "right" choice for sleep, leading to hesitation, second-guessing, and frustration instead of calm.

**Problem 5 — Sleep Becomes a Performance, Not a Natural Transition**
Users feel pressure to "do sleep right," which heightens self-awareness and paradoxically makes it harder to relax and fall asleep.

**Problem 6 — No Clear Transition From Setup to Sleep**
Even after users complete setup (choosing content, setting timers), there is no strong moment of intention-setting that helps them mentally shift into sleep mode.

**Problem 7 — Calm's Sleep Value Is Not Obvious Enough**
When the sleep experience feels unstructured or demanding, users question why Calm is better than a generic podcast or music app.

**Requirement 1: Zero-Decision "Sleep Now" Mode**
**Problem addressed:** Cognitive overload, choice fatigue
**Product requirement**
- Single tap from "Sleep Now"
- No content selection screen
- System auto-selects content based on:
  - time of night
  - recent successful sleep sessions
  - user listening history
- Sleep timer enabled by default

**Success metric**
- Reduced time from app open → playback
- Increased sleep completion rate

**Requirement 2: Situational Sleep States (Not Content Browsing)**
**Problem addressed:** Content discovery friction
**Product requirement**
- Replace large libraries with 4–6 sleep-specific states (e.g., Overthinking, Lonely, Anxious)
- Each state offers a maximum of 1–2 options
- No scrolling required

**Success metric**
- Time to first play before playback
- Higher first-choice success rate

**Requirement 3: Failure-Aware Adaptive Playback**
**Problem addressed:** Frustration when sleep does not occur
**Product requirement**
- Detect signals of restlessness during playback
- Automatically adapt by:
  - switching to simpler sounds
  - reducing narrative complexity
  - lowering sound intensity
- Avoid performance messaging (optional, minimal)

**Success metric**
- Reduced session abandonment
- Improved sleep onset after adaptation

**Requirement 4: Sleep-First, Disappearing Interface**
**Problem addressed:** Visual and interaction stimulation
**Product requirement**
- Screen auto-dims to minimum and locks after playback starts
- No visible controls, progress bars, or recommendations
- UI intentionally disappears

**Success metric**
- Reduced screen-on time
- Fewer accidental interactions during sessions

**Requirement 5: Distraction Elimination by Default**
**Problem addressed:** Phone remains a distraction
**Product requirement**
- Prompt or auto-enable Do Not Disturb
- Minimal notifications (only critical errors or system-level confirmation)
- Clear "no further action needed" signaling

**Success metric**
- Lower app switching during sleep sessions
- Higher uninterrupted playback duration

**Primary Problem Statement (Core, Structural)**
**Calm's sleep experience asks users to make too many decisions and stay digitally engaged at a moment of low cognitive energy, which increases mental stimulation and delays the transition into sleep.**
**Why this is a killer PS**
- Explains **decision fatigue, cognitive overload, loss of momentum,** and **break in immersion**.
- Directly contradicts the user's core job: *de-stimulate and disengage*
- Clearly "status quo changing" — it questions Calm's content-discovery model for sleep
- Very prototype-able (you can test reduced decision-making or guided flow)

**Secondary Problem Statement (Emotional / Behavioral Layer)**
**Users lack confidence and reassurance during the sleep setup process, causing them to overthink choices, feel pressure to "do sleep right," and remain mentally preoccupied instead of relaxing.**
**Why this matters**
- Adds **emotional friction, paradoxical insomnia,** and **preoccupied mental state**
- Explains why browsing and second-guessing happen
- Strongly tied to *emotional reassurance, intention setting, and trust*

**1. Typical user-side pain points**
1. Subscription and billing frustrations
- Many users complain about auto-charging after a free trial, difficulty canceling, and hard refunds, calling the app "greedy."
- Pricing and renewal terms are not always clearly surfaced, so users feel tricked and lose trust.
2. Slow or unhelpful customer support
- When billing or technical issues like logins, inaccessible content, or duplicate charges, they often get stuck in email loops with bots and no resolution.
- There is no easy, real-time human support, which makes people feel even more anxious when something goes wrong.
3. Usability and technical stability
- Both the app and website are often described as clunky and buggy, with problems after updates, missing favorites, or accounts that suddenly stop working.
- The information architecture is noisy, so a tired or stressed user still has to dig through multiple sections to find the right track.
4. Hard to discover the right content
- New users do not know where to start or how to build a systematic practice, they just wander in a big content library.
- The product does not clearly translate goals like "better sleep" or "less anxiety" into structured paths and many users do not even know certain features exist.
5. Repetitive content and weak personalization
- Long-time users feel content is repetitive and not refreshed quickly enough.
- Recommendations feel generic, not truly tuned to a user's mood, habits, or completion history.
6. Not friendly enough for beginners
- The app assumes prior knowledge of meditation, with a high barrier for people who have never meditated.
- There is little sense of levels or progression, so beginners end up randomly choosing something and hoping it is not too hard.
7. Gap between brand promise and reality
- Calm promises to make you calmer, but when billing, bugs, and support issues show up, users actually feel more stressed.
- This expectation gap hurts the brand more than a "normal" utility app would.

**2. Competitors and how they solved these issues**
1. Revenue vs trust trade-off
- The company is under pressure to hit subscription and retention targets, which pushes more aggressive trial and billing flows.
- As PM, you must choose between short-term revenue lifts and long-term NPS and trust, and Calm currently leans too much toward short-term.
2. Internal resistance to "frethering" users
- Any friction you add to improve trust (extra confirmations, more consent using push notifications because the team was afraid of being annoying.
- This culture makes it hard to design strong nudges to help people build habits: push too hard and you break the brand, but stay too soft and you fail to drive behavior change.
3. Content-driven vs experience-driven focus
- Calm's past success came from premium content IP (bedtime stories, celebrity voices), so it is easy to keep doubling down on "more content."
- But users' core complaints now are not about volume; they are about relevance, discoverability, and how to use the product.
4. Global competition and legacy constraints
- Big competitors like Headspace, Insight Timer, and newer AI-driven apps, personalization and "feels like it understands me" are becoming table stakes.
- Calm has a heavier legacy product and brand to maintain, which makes fast pivots and bold UX changes harder.

**3. Product-level improvements**
**1) Trust subscription and support as core journeys, not back-office**
- Redesign the trial and billing flows to be radically transparent: clear trial end dates, proactive reminders, and a truly low-friction cancel experience.
- Build an in-app "Billing & Subscription Center" where users can see status, upcoming charges, and refund options in one place.
- Add human support (that or scheduled callback) for high-stress issues like access and billing, using automation only as assist, not a shield.

**2) Move from "content library" to "visual growth paths"**
- Make the home screen answer "What should I do today?" based on each user's goal and state instead of throwing lots of categories at them.
- Design structured programs (Journeys) like "7-day meditation starter," "14-day sleep reset," or "Work anxiety toolkit," with visual progress and completion signals.
- Use onboarding to capture goals, available time, and preferences and feed that into a daily plan rather than one-off recommendations.

**3) Build real emotion- and behavior-based personalization**
- Combine lightweight mood check-ins with behavioral data (time of day, session length, streaks) to adapt recommended content and duration.
- Add a recommendation strategy that actively avoids showing the same items again and again to long-time users.
- Provide a brief explanation for recommendations ("We suggest this because you've been going to bed after 1am this week") to increase trust.

**4) Lower the barrier for absolute beginners**
- Offer a "0 to 1" beginner track: guided sessions with only short (3–5 minute) guided sessions and minimal jargon.
- Tag each session with clear difficulty and audience labels so beginners can quickly pick "the first timers" content.
- Introduce light social proof (e.g., "12,000 people are also doing this today") to make practice feel less lonely without turning it into a noisy social network.

**5) Align brand promise with "stressful moments" in the journey**
- Ensure every critical touchpoint (billing, cancel, support) reflects the brand's promised calm, empathetic language and reassuring UX patterns.
- Design explicit "anger recovery" paths when a user hits repeated failures: quick apology, small compensation, and faster human support.
- Publish regular "product health updates" that show what has been fixed or improved recently to build the sense that the team is actively caring for users.

**Calm - Sleep Experience**
**Key Pain Points & Product Requirements**

**1. Core User Pain Points**
**1. Cognitive overload at bedtime**
- Users open Calm when mentally exhausted, anxious, or overstimulated
- Too many options trigger decision fatigue instead of choose
- Decision-making itself becomes a blocker to sleep

**Insight:** At bedtime, users want certainty, not control.

**2. Choice overload & content discovery friction**
- Large libraries create paralysis instead of value
- Mood labels are vague and not situational
- Search is cognitively demanding when users don't know what they want
- Users feel stressed by "choosing the right thing to fall asleep"

**Insight:** Choice fatigue directly contradicts Calm's sleep promise.

**3. Interface is not truly sleep-first**
- Screen remains bright and interactive
- Timer behavior is inconsistent across content
- Volume and sound intensity vary unexpectedly
- Users must manually manage phone settings (brightness, notifications, screen off)

**Insight:** The app continues to demand attention after playback begins.

**4. Distractions persist during use**
- Notifications remain active
- Easy to switch to social media or other apps
- Calm does not fully help users exit the phone environment

**Insight:** Calm competes with the phone instead of neutralizing it.

**5. Poor handling of failure to fall asleep**
- When users don't fall asleep, frustration increases
- Repetitive or mismatched content creates negative feedback loops
- Users blame themselves rather than the system

**Insight:** Sleep failure is common but not designed for.

**Requirement 6: Single-Tap Personalized Hook to Reset Inertia**
**Problem addressed:** Users open Calm with a specific goal (sleep, focus, anxiety) but lose momentum when they land on the app's generic home screen, where they must navigate through many options before finding the right tool. This friction breaks the intended ritual and increases the chance they drift to other apps instead of completing their intended session.
**Product requirement**
- Home screen shows a single, personalized hook based on time of day, recent usage, and stated goal
- Hook examples: "Pick up where you left off," "Your 3-minute focus session is ready," "Wind down for tonight"
- Tapping the hook launches the relevant session in one tap, with no intermediate screens
- Hook updates dynamically as the user completes sessions or changes their goal

**Success metric**
- Time from app open to first session start
- Percentage of app opens that result in a session lasting more than 60 seconds
- Number of sessions per weekly active user

**Requirement 7: Ambient Sleep Mode Without Screen Dependence**
**Problem addressed:** Users want to fall asleep without being pulled back into the app by notifications, screen brightness, or the temptation to check something else. The current experience still requires phone interaction throughout the session, which undermines the goal of disconnecting from screens at night.
**Product requirement**
- Sleep timer runs in the background with screen dimmed or off
- Minimal interface: only pause, stop, and time remaining visible
- Notifications suppressed during active sleep sessions
- Gentle haptic or audio cue when the session ends, not a wake-up alarm

**Success metric**
- Percentage of sessions completed without opening the app after playback begins
- Reduction in screen-on time during sessions
- Number of notifications sent during active sessions that users dismiss without opening

**Requirement 8: Morning Reflection Prompt to Close the Loop**
**Problem addressed:** Users have no way to record how they slept or how the session affected them. Without this, there is no feedback loop between the session and the next one, so the app cannot learn from outcomes or show users that their practice is working.
**Product requirement**
- Single question prompt the morning after a session: "How did you sleep?" or "How do you feel this morning?"
- Three-option response: better / same / worse
- Response stored and used to adjust future session recommendations
- Optional: show a streak or simple count of consecutive days with a session

**Success metric**
- Percentage of users who answer the morning prompt
- Correlation between morning ratings and session completion rates
- Number of users who return for a second session after a session rated "worse"

**Requirement 9: Sleep Onset Detection and Adaptive Ending**
**Problem addressed:** Users fall asleep before the session ends and then lose the benefit of the remaining time. The app has no way to know when the user has stopped listening, so it cannot adapt its ending to match actual sleep behavior.
**Product requirement**
- Detect signs of sleep onset (reduced movement, audio patterns, or user inactivity)
- Automatically fade audio and dim screen when sleep is detected
- Log the estimated sleep onset time for each session
- Use sleep onset data to suggest better session lengths over time

**Success metric**
- Percentage of sessions where sleep onset is detected before the session ends
- Average difference between estimated sleep onset and user-reported sleep time
- Reduction in sessions that run to completion without sleep onset

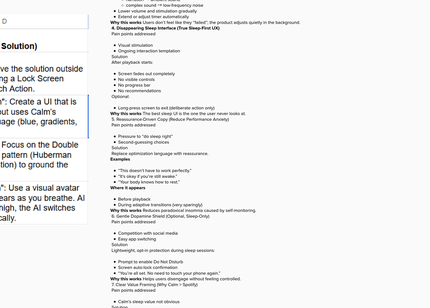
**Requirement 10: Sleep Streak and Consistency Signal**
**Problem addressed:** Users have no visible record of their sleep practice and no reason to return tomorrow beyond habit. There is no feedback that rewards consistency or makes missed days feel like a loss worth avoiding.
**Product requirement**
- Streak counter on the home screen showing consecutive days with a completed session
- Streak resets after a missed day, with no penalty language
- Optional: show total sessions this week or this month

**Success metric**
- Percentage of users who return for a second session the next day
- Average streak length across active users
- Number of users who restart a streak after a reset



CRUNCH TIME (DONE BY 2/11)
1. DETAIL 3 PERSONALIZED JOURNEY FOR ANGRY, ANXIETY, LONLINESS) -SHIV, SAI (BY TMR MORNING)
2. UPDATING PROTOTYPE -SOPHIA,(BY NOON)
3. COME UP WITH USER INTERVIEW GUIDELINES - SAI
4. KEEP WORKING ON WIRETTRER -TIFF
5. PRESENTATION SLIDES -PRANAV
6. INDIVIDUAL USER INTERVIEWS (NOTES, RECORDING) -ALL (TMR AFTERNOON)

| A | B | C | D |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Emotion** | **Step 1: The "DONE" Moment(Personalized Hook to Reset Inertia)**<br>Target: Underdoses (Relaxed/Anger recovery discharge) and Overdoses (Sleep/Anxiety relief)<br>Immediately The Interaction: "The Sun." The screen shifts from cold blue to a specific, warm color based on the user's goal (e.g., "Traffic"). They swipe up, and the world physically "Matters" to Sunny with strong haptic feedback.<br>Why it works (Neuroscience/Physics): The brain needs a vague final point to stop spinning. The interaction "The Place" is visual (only Underdoses) and tactile (only Overdoses).<br>The user's chosen "Island" (e.g., a Beach or Church) becomes the destination for the session. | **Step 2: The Scientific Grounding(Physiological Intervention)**<br>Scientific Basis: The "Physiological Sigh" (Huberman Lab). This is the fastest way to calm a cold blood. The Guide: A "Coach" Avatar (e.g., Sunny) appears and explains the exercise (Inhale, Inhale, Long Exhale) This is the fastest way to offload CO2 and slow the heart rate. A soothing voice explains the "Why" (Vagus nerve stimulation, NO-mimetics) Script: "Stay with me. Two sniffs in, one long sigh out."<br>Target: Clarity (Sunny) and Calm (Sea) | **Step 3: Build Action Items(What to Produce)**<br>Scenario: The "Anger" Journey<br>Animation: "Shatter" effect with heavy haptics. The screen cracks and shatters (demo but supportive) A. Audio: Deep, rhythmic vibration.<br>B. Text: Text appears in a floating circle that matches the "Cracks Inside" rhythm 2. Mascot: A calm, non-threatening mascot (Sunny) appears. Text: "Anger Burst Recent (Inhale-Inhale)... Long Sigh Out (Exhale)."<br>3. Photo Frame: Pre-loaded image of user's daughter (or Cherished Person) appears. Text: "Hold her in your mind." (Count over the photo) 3. Audio: Transition to a calm, steady beat. 60 BPM to entrain the user's pulse. |
| **Anger / Frustration(High Energy, Heat)** | | | |
| **Anxiety / Overwhelmed(Fear, Blind, Chaos)** | | | |
| **Fear / Scared(Flight Response, Freeze)** | | | |




**Workflow, Emotion - Frustration/Angry:**
1. Breathing exercises for 3mins - either bubble or avatar
2. Avatar to check in on status
3. Reassuring message
4. Transition out based on user status

**Workflow, Emotion - Anxious / Overwhelmed**
1. Breathing exercises for 3mins - either bubble or avatar
2. Avatar to check in on status
3. Reassuring message
4. Transition out based on user status

**User Personas (Types of Users Using Calm)**
1. Frustrated/Angry
2. Anxious
3. Scared
4. Lonely / Neglected
5. Overwhelmed / Low Self Esteem

## Design Ideas and Competitive Research: Non Clinical Stressful Situations

**Step 1 Low Design Barrier to Access**
a. Quick 'SOS' Button on home screen
b. Easy to access 'Panic Button'
c. Maybe a lightweight sandalone app just for Panic/Stress?

**2. Step 2: The DOSE Bridge**
a. Quick Breathing Exercise
b. Chemistry that momentum towards grounding with CBT
c. Personalized mascot / virtual character to guide
d. Photos of loved ones

**3 Step 3: Grounding**
a. Quick Games
b. CBT based psychological methods
c. Anything else scientific and personalized

**4. Step 4: Reflection?**

**Step 2 Solution Ideas - Pranav:**
1. Mascot (Sydney Sweeney/Dua Lipa for Pranav) appears asking to you to understand your problem
2. Highlight rest of photos of loved ones
3. Quick game for escapism

1. Mascot appears slowly - gentle animation - floating, breathing, gentle glow maybe?
2. Deepens emotional safety - breathes with you, mirrors your breathing pace
3. Guides tiny actions - sip of water, uncliench, roll shoulders - can even do it with you (visually)
4. Then closed emotion and maybe specific exercises
5. reflection

Solutions to Calm down
1) Mini Games (Pranav)
2) Emotional Mascot - Pre-added text/ voice
3) Comedy show/ TV Show Clip
4) Puzzle/ Exercise
5) Cute Animal Reassurance
6) Combination
7) Song/ Calming Soundtrack
8) Virtual Hug
9) Scenic Picture of Nature

**Step 1 Solution Ideas - Kari / Shiva / Tiff:**
1) Personalized Colors for Day & Night
2) Character Photo/ Avatar (Loved/ Personal)
3) Chat & or / Voice
4) Calm Down Button
5) Support Level Scroller
6) Separate Sleep Timer Setup in dark mode
7) Separate screen button sections and add a immediate solution
8) Standalone app
9) Calm Down section
10) Sleep sleep permanent notification
11) Widgets
12) Heart Rate tracker - watch
13) Bed time reminder

Provide an immediate, one-tap access point for users in acute stress, minimizing cognitive load and decision-making at the moment of distress.

A persistent SOS / Panic button on the home screen
No setup, no content browsing, no choices before activation

Instant 60-Second Calm Exercise
A 30–60 second audio-play calming sequence triggered immediately after Panic Mode starts
Guided slow-paced breathing visual with Calm soundscapes
Requires zero user interaction

A simple AI companion Chat that stays with users during moments of stress, offering supportive responses and gently guiding them toward calm.

Step 1 – Entry
- Users tap "Calm Down" or "Need to Talk"
- They are taken directly into the AI Companion Chat
- No onboarding, no character setup, no explanation required

Step 2 – Meet the AI Does (Core Experience)
The AI is intentionally constrained to three types of interactions only:
1. Acknowledgement
   - "I'm here with you."
   - "That sounds really overwhelming."
2. Gentle Reflection
   - "Your breathing today has been nonstop."
   - No interpretation, no judgment
   - "Would it help to slow your breathing for 30 seconds?"

Step 3 – Transition Out
- AI appropriate moments, the AI suggests:
  - "We can sit quietly for a moment."
  - Or "I can play a short breathing exercise with you."

Within the session, users can move into:
- Breathing
- Soundscapes
- Sleep content

"Which feeling feels closest to how you are right now?"
- Tired
- Empty
- Sad
- Tense
- Overwhelmed

Use simple two-choice or four-choice options to avoid open-ended input.

Personalized Companionship: Mascot / Virtual Character Guidance
Objective: Reduce psychological defensiveness and build long-term engagement.
Feature Description: A low-presence, non-preachy virtual character.
The character can take the form of a public figure, a family member, or a friend.
The character does not "tell users what to do," but rather "stays with them and does it together."

Character Traits: Gentle and concise tone
No professional or clinical psychological terminology
No value judgments or evaluations

Personalization Options: Users can choose the character's style (more rational, more gentle, or more quiet)

## Critical User Journey

**Key Assumptions we want to check**
1. Will users find this option when anxious?
2. Will this actually calm them down?
3. Can this become a habit? - Can't be checked
4. Is there a novelty effect? - Can't be checked
5. Is there friction / Usability Issues
6. Does mascot/ avatar resonate?
7. Will people do the longer onboarding to add what we need?

**What we're testing for:**
1. Does this make Calm when they're stressed?
2. Does our 3 step process work and help a user to Calm down?

Great question — this is exactly the right next step for this feature.I'll keep this **tightly aligned to your SOS journey** and focus on **what actually matters in a high-stress context** (not generic usability questions).
Below is a **practical user testing framework** you can use immediately.
1⃣ What kind of user testing is this?
This is **NOT** feature discovery testing.This is **crisis-moment usability + emotional validation testing**.
Your core question is **not**:
"Do users like this feature?"
It is:
**"Does this help users when they are emotionally overloaded?"**
That changes everything about what you test.
2⃣ Primary testing goals (what you must validate)
**Goal 1 — Immediate usability**
1. **Visibility & Instinct**
   - Do users notice SOS without being told?
2. **Cognitive Load**
   - Can users move through the flow without thinking?
**Goal 2 — Emotional impact**
3. **Emotional Relief**
   - Do users feel understood, not judged or confused?
4. **Immediate Relief**
   - Do users feel even slightly better after using it?
If your testing doesn't answer these, it's noise.
3⃣ What to test (minimum viable setup)
Test setup (recommended):
- Use **scenario-based testing**
- Do **NOT** explain the feature first.
- Put users in a **simulated stressed state**
Example scenarios:
"Imagine it's late at night. You're feeling overwhelmed and can't calm down. You open Calm."
Then observe.
4⃣ Key user testing questions (by stage of your journey)
A. Home / Sleep Page → SOS Discovery
**What good looks like**
- Does SOS pull attention naturally-without explanation?
**Questions to ask**
- "What's the first thing you notice on this screen?"
- "If you were feeling overwhelmed, what would you tap first?"
- "What do you think tapping here that feels meant for right now?"
**What good looks like**
- User taps SOS without being prompted
- Or verbally says: "I'd probably tap SOS"
🟥 Red flag:
- User ignores SOS
- Or says: "I'd scroll first"
B. Understanding Screen
**What you're testing**
- Emotional resonance, not accuracy
**Questions to ask**
- "Which option would you choose without overthinking?"
- "Does any option feel too intense/too simple?"
- "Do you feel pressure to choose 'the correct one'?"
- "How does the 'I don't know what I feel' option make you feel?"
**What good looks like**
- Quick selection
- Comments like "I don't know what I feel"
- Comments like "This feels about right"/ like that I don't have to be precise"
🟥 Red flag:
- User hesitates too long
- Asks: "What's the difference between these?"
C. Immediate Calm Screen
⭐ Personalized CBT / Immediate Calm Screen
**What you're testing**
- Does the experience reduce intensity, even slightly?
**Questions to ask**
- "How do you feel compared to before you started?"
- "Does this feel supportive or instructive?"
- "Is there anything here that feels distracting or unnecessary?"
- "Would you want to continue, or does this already feel like enough?"
**What good looks like**
- User reports even small relief."A little calmer"/"Less tense"/"I could keep going"
🟥 Red flag:
- User says"I'd probably exit"/"This feels like too much"/"I don't want to think right now"
D. Overall Flow Reflection (Very Important)
Ask **only at the end**:
- "Did this feel like the app understood what you needed in that moment?"
- "At any point, did this feel less worse?"
- "Did anything make you more anxious or mentally overwhelmed?"
- "What part helped the most — or hurt the most?"
This tells you whether the **entire journey holds emotionally**.
5⃣ What NOT to ask (this is crucial)
❌ "Do you like this feature?"❌ "Would you use this offer?"❌ "Is this better than Calm today?"❌ "Should we add more options?"
These questions mislead and will mislead you.
6⃣ Key signals to watch (more important than answers)
During testing, watch for:
- Long pauses before tapping
- Sighs of relief
- Immediate tapping
- "Oh, this is nice"
- "I don't have to decide"
These **non-verbal cues** matter more than ratings.
7⃣ Success criteria (simple & honest)
**Minimum viable success**
- Users find SOS without instruction
- Users don't feel forced to label emotions
- Users report **any** reduction in emotional intensity
- No one feels judged, rushed, or confused
You do **not** need delight.You need **safety + relief**.
8⃣ If you want a one-sentence testing goal (for class / stakeholders)
"We want to know if stressed users can intuitively access SOS, move through the flow with minimal cognitive effort, and experience immediate emotional relief."